

CHAPTER 4 — WHEN TERROR MEETS SORROW

Far to the southeast of Velldendar, Alaric Branwood climbed into the mountains in search of Frostheart Edelweiss, a rare herb he desperately needed for Itha. Her fever had worsened, and he had already used the last of the medicine kept at the hut. Despite the pain in his lower back and a dangerous slip during the climb, Alaric reached the higher ledges and gathered enough Frostheart to treat her.

While collecting the herbs, Alaric remembered the night Itha's fever began. She had been preparing food beside the hearth when she suddenly collapsed, her strange bandages catching her before she hit the floor. Alaric carried her to bed, where she complained of pain in her chest and a strange feeling in her heart before he realized how dangerously high her fever had become.

On the journey home, Alaric followed red ribbons he had tied along the rivers and crossings, remembering Old Odran, the man who had taken him in as a child and taught him how to use the knots to find his way through the wilderness. But as Alaric neared the rope bridge leading back toward the hut, he began hearing a man weeping in the distance.

The voice was the same mysterious one that had led him to Itha almost three months earlier. When Alaric followed it, he found a Nightmare standing motionless before the bridge. The sight dragged him back to an earlier encounter with the creatures, when he had watched them slaughter Redmaw warriors and narrowly escaped one himself.

Then the Nightmare called Alaric by name. Its head twisted unnaturally toward him as black ichor ran from its eyes like tears, but instead of attacking, it pointed toward the path home and begged him to hurry, warning that "the maggots are coming." Fearing something had happened to Itha, Alaric forced himself past the creature and onto the bridge, his fear of the Nightmare overwhelmed by a single thought: getting home to her.

On the far side of the bridge, Alaric stopped, not because he wanted to, but because his body forced him to.

He stood bent over his staff, one hand locked around the wood while the other pressed against his side where the satchel hung, his breath tearing out of him in pale, ragged clouds while his lower back burned from the crossing, from the climb and from every hurried step that had brought him this far, until for several heartbeats all he could do was gather enough strength to keep standing.

Then he looked back across the bridge.

The Nightmare remained on the other side, motionless against the pale winter landscape, its long arm still raised while one finger pointed toward the path behind Alaric, and only its head remained twisted toward him, watching across the distance with those hollow eyes while black ichor continued to trail down its ruined face.

Alaric stared at it for several breaths, waiting for the slightest movement, but nothing came, no step onto the bridge, no sudden rush across the planks and no black bandages reaching after him, only that impossible stare and the broken weeping that still drifted faintly through the cold.

His fingers tightened around the staff as the warning returned with such clarity that for an instant he could almost hear the creature speaking again, that familiar male voice forced through a mouth that had no right to carry it.

The maggots are coming.

Alaric frowned through his fear.

Maggots?

The word made less sense now than it had moments before, because maggots were small things, pale and blind, born in rot and left to writhe inside what death had already claimed, unpleasant certainly, but hardly something that should frighten a Nightmare; they did not come like soldiers through the trees, they did not hunt, and they certainly did not seem like something that should make a creature such as that beg him to hurry.

Yet there had been fear in those words, a desperation that made the warning impossible to dismiss, because whatever had spoken through the Nightmare had not merely warned him that the maggots were coming.

It had sounded afraid of them.

But even that was not what troubled Alaric most.

He was certain now that it had to be the same voice he had heard almost three months ago, the one that had guided him through the snow until he found Itha, and hearing it again through the mouth of a Nightmare stripped away what little doubt he had allowed himself to keep that whoever had led him to her then was the same person speaking to him now.

Alaric's brow tightened as he stared at the distant figure, but whatever questions followed would have to wait, because the hut remained less than thirty minutes ahead and every moment he spent standing there was another moment away from her.

Itha.

She had been resting when he left her, and he wanted nothing more than to reach the door and find her exactly there, to hold her again, hear her voice and feel foolish for allowing the terror inside him to grow into something larger than the truth.

Less than thirty minutes remained between him and knowing.

Alaric pulled his eyes away from the Nightmare and forced himself forward.

The last of the winter light had begun to drain from the forest, sunset bleeding weakly through the trees and stretching long shadows across the snow as nightfall crept closer with every passing minute.

Alaric leaned more of his weight onto the staff and drove himself onward, using it like a third leg whenever his body threatened to betray him, while each hurried step sent pain biting through his lower back, deeper now and sharper, as if the old ache had been waiting for this moment to become cruel.

It caught hard enough to tear a small sound from him before he could swallow it, but Alaric clenched his teeth until his jaw hurt and pushed faster, because pain could have him later, fear could have him later and everything else could have him later, if only he reached the door, crossed the threshold and saw for himself that the terror building inside him was wrong.

The path home stretched ahead in a narrow line of churned snow and black roots, and he kept his attention fixed upon it, holding to the familiar bend between the pines, the slight rise in the ground and the slope that would soon carry him closer to the hut, until something entered the edge of his vision and drew his gaze toward a figure standing between the trees that, for one brief and impossible moment, he thought he had left behind on the other side of the bridge.

Another Nightmare stood ahead.

Alaric almost stopped when he saw it waiting there, tall and black and hollow, but it did not step into his path and it did not reach for him; only one long arm remained raised, its finger pointing through the falling snow toward the hut while black bandages drifted from the pitch-black void where the front of its chest should have been.

For one terrible moment, Alaric simply stared.

There should not have been another one here, not on this side of the bridge and not this close to home.

He tightened his grip around the staff and approached, every muscle in his body prepared for the moment the creature would lunge while the same broken weeping he had heard at the bridge spilled from its hollow mouth, louder now without the distance between them, yet the attack never came, and instead the creature's head began to turn after him while the rest of its body remained perfectly still, its neck twisting slowly with a dry, splintering crack as Alaric passed.

His heart struck hard against his ribs, but he kept moving.

Only a short distance farther, another Nightmare waited between the trees, and when Alaric came near its head turned too, its own miserable weeping joining the cry behind him until the two voices overlapped in an uneven mourning that seemed to follow him along the path.

Another appeared beyond it.

Then another.

Within only a few minutes, the gaps between them began shrinking so rapidly that what had first seemed like isolated creatures scattered through the forest became something far more deliberate, and with every new figure came another hollow voice until the weeping no longer seemed to belong to any one creature.

Every time his eyes found another, his heart sank lower, and every time another voice joined the others, the pressure inside his chest tightened with it, making each breath feel shorter while his fingers closed harder around the staff.

Each Nightmare stood closer to the hut than the last, their long arms raised in the same direction as though the forest itself had grown fingers pointing him home, and every new black shape between the trees sent another cold stab through his chest, urging him onward before his mind could form the possibilities gathering around him.

Then the pattern stirred a memory he had tried not to think about.

This was not the first time the Nightmares had gathered in numbers.

More than a month ago, they had appeared without warning in the forest beyond the bridge, scattered among the trees on the far side and standing so still that Alaric had barely believed they were alive at all, and unlike the creatures surrounding him now, they had not wandered or hunted, had not reacted to his presence and had not made a sound.

They had been nothing like the Nightmares he remembered from the night he had first encountered them either, when one had chased him through the forest while others tore into the Redmaw Tribe with a violence that had left no doubt about what they were capable of.

These had done nothing at all, remaining there for hours without moving, as though whatever terrible purpose normally drove them had simply disappeared and left behind only empty shapes staring through the winter woods.

Even before that gathering, Velldengar had already begun to feel less safe than it once had.

The war between Kalluth and the Bloodmoon Tribes continued to rage farther north, spreading uncertainty across the land with every passing week, and although the little hut in the south had remained far from the fighting, Alaric had known better than to believe that distance alone could protect them forever.

For a time, he had been willing to accept that uncertainty, telling himself that this part of the forest was far enough removed from the war and that whatever happened between Kalluth and the tribes did not necessarily have to reach them.

Then the Nightmares appeared.

Seeing so many of them gathered beyond the bridge had been the final blow, because whatever danger the war might one day bring toward their home, those creatures were already there, standing close enough that Alaric could watch them between the trees from the place he had slowly begun allowing himself to think of as safe.

They needed to leave Velldengar.

Whatever attachment he had formed to the hut and whatever small comfort they had managed to build within its walls, none of it had seemed worth gambling Itha's life for, and he had tried to convince her that there would be somewhere else, somewhere farther from the fighting and beyond those forests where they could begin again without waking each morning wondering what might be standing between the trees.

Even as the memory pulled him deeper into that day, Alaric's body continued driving itself along the path, his steps growing more desperate until he was nearly running despite the pain tearing through his lower back, the staff striking hard into the snow whenever his legs threatened to fail him while the hut somewhere ahead seemed to pull at him with every breath.

Itha had pleaded with him not to go.

She had wanted to stay in that little hut with a desperation he had not understood at first, refusing every quiet promise he made that they could find another place and listening with growing distress each time he tried to explain that a home meant nothing if remaining inside it eventually got her killed, until at last the reason came from her in a voice so small that it silenced every argument he still carried.

She did not want to lose another home.

Alaric had not known everything hidden behind those words, and even now there were pieces of Itha's past she had never given him, but he had understood enough to know that she was not speaking only about timber, a roof or the few belongings they had gathered inside it, because whatever that little hut had become to her, leaving it behind would have meant losing something she had only just begun allowing herself to believe she possessed.

His mind had told him that staying was foolish, because everything he knew about the Nightmares and everything he had heard about the war told him to take her and put as much distance between them and danger as his body would allow, yet when she asked him not to take this home away from her, something in the way her voice broke around the words made his heart refuse what his mind insisted was right.

He had spent so long thinking only of keeping her alive that he had almost forgotten survival was not the only thing a person could lose.

So they stayed, not because the war had become any less dangerous or because Alaric had suddenly begun to believe the Nightmares harmless, but because leaving would have meant becoming the reason Itha lost another place she had only just begun allowing herself to call home, and that was something he could not bring himself to take from her.

Later that night, he had tried to make her understand what he had failed to explain before, that none of it had ever truly been about the hut or what little they owned, because if leaving Velldenar meant keeping her beyond the reach of the war, the Nightmares or anything else that might one day find them there, then he would have abandoned all of it without hesitation.

The only thing that had mattered was her.

He had promised that whatever waited beyond those walls, whatever came looking for them and wherever they were eventually forced to go, he would be there, and he would do everything his broken body allowed to make certain she remained safe.

Itha had answered him with the same certainty, telling him that no evil would ever step into their home for as long as they had each other.

Those words had remained with him.

By the next morning, the Nightmares were gone.

When Alaric left the hut to gather herbs, the part of the forest where they had stood the day before was empty, the black shapes between the trees replaced by disturbed snow and the marks they had left behind, while their footprints stretched away from the area in a long, broken trail leading farther south toward the mountains.

Alaric had never understood why they had come, why they had remained there for so long without moving or what had finally drawn them away, but in the days that followed they did not return and eventually that part of the forest began to feel quiet again.

Until now.

The memory loosened its hold on him as another sharp pain tore through his lower back, dragging him fully into the present, and when Alaric lifted his head he realized that while his thoughts had wandered backward, his body had never stopped carrying him home.

The familiar bend in the path was already behind him and the ground had begun to rise beneath his boots.

He was close.

Only a few more minutes separated him from the hut now, only a little farther before the trees would thin enough for him to see the roof between them, before he could reach the door, cross the threshold and finally see Itha again, and the realization sent a desperate warmth through his chest that pushed against the fear surrounding him.

“Don’t worry, Itha,” Alaric whispered between ragged breaths as he forced another step through the snow. “I’m almost there, and I won’t let anything happen to you, even if I have to carry you away from every Nightmare in this forest myself.”

The thought almost made something inside him soften despite everything around him, because he could already imagine how badly his body would punish him for attempting such a thing, how his lower back would scream beneath her weight and how every step would become its own battle, yet none of it mattered, because if carrying her was what it took to put distance between Itha and the creatures surrounding their home, then he would carry her until his legs could no longer hold him.

Alaric pushed himself harder.

Around him, the Nightmares continued their endless weeping, their long bodies standing between the trees with the same terrible stillness he had begun to expect from them, their heads turning after him while black bandages drifted through the falling snow and raised arms pointed him onward, and despite the fear tightening every muscle in his body, some small part of him had already begun to understand the pattern they had followed since the bridge.

They watched him, they wept and they pointed him home, but none of them approached.

That certainty lasted only another step.

Something moved to his right.

Alaric barely had time to register the blur of black between the trees before one of the Nightmares tore itself out of the stillness with a speed so completely unlike anything the others had shown that his mind failed to understand what was happening until it was already upon him.

Its hand closed around his right arm.

Alaric gasped as the force of it twisted him sideways, his left hand remaining locked around the staff while the Nightmare's long fingers wrapped around his upper arm and held him with enough strength to stop him completely, its claws pressing through the fabric and barely breaking the skin beneath, shallow enough that they did little more than hold him but strong enough that pulling free immediately felt impossible.

He did not fight.

For that first moment, he could not.

The creature was suddenly too close.

Its hollow face hovered only a breath from his own, filling Alaric's vision so completely that for a moment there was nothing else, and before he could gather enough thought to pull away, something inside the Nightmare seemed to break.

Its body convulsed.

The movement was wrong even for something as unnatural as this, its spine snapping backward while its shoulders jerked in opposite directions and the open void where its chest should have been warped around the movement, pitch black and empty at the front while the black bandages spilling from within twisted violently through the hollow space as though some unseen force were wrenching the creature apart around that emptiness.

Its neck twisted.

The bandages thrashed through the void and then drew sharply inward again as the creature's entire frame seized around Alaric, every limb trembling at once while whatever force had taken hold of it seemed to gather into one final violent movement.

Alaric could only stare.

The Nightmare suddenly folded forward until its hollow face was almost against his.

Its mouth tore open.

Then it shrieked.

The sound exploded through the forest with such force that the endless weeping vanished beneath it, every other Nightmare falling silent for one impossible moment while birds burst from the branches all around them and fled through the winter sky in a frantic storm of wings.

Alaric's breath stopped.

He knew that voice.

Itha.

The realization struck harder than the creature's grip.

It was not merely similar to her voice and it was not something his fear had twisted into familiarity, because every broken edge of that shriek belonged to Itha, raw and deep and filled with a pain so terrible that for one confused heartbeat Alaric expected to find her standing somewhere beside him.

But she was not there.

Only the Nightmare stood before him, its hollow face almost touching his while Itha's voice poured from its mouth.

The claws pressed more firmly into his arm, yet Alaric barely felt them, because terror had swallowed everything else and left him staring helplessly at the creature while the shriek continued to tear through him.

His breath returned in broken pieces, one gasp followed by another that never seemed to reach deeply enough, while something about the sound seemed to enter him with the air and settle behind his ribs as a pressure so heavy that his body instinctively tried to fold around it.

The Nightmare's grip would not allow him to collapse.

It held him upright on legs that barely remembered how to carry his weight while the scream seemed to remain inside him even after the creature's mouth finally fell silent, trapped somewhere beneath his chest and pressing outward as though it were trying to tear its way free.

A tear gathered beneath one of Alaric's eyelids and slipped down his face before he even realized it was there, followed by another as the terror carried inside Itha's voice settled deeper than any claw could have reached, because the sound had been so raw, so close and so horribly real that for several moments he could not separate what he knew from what his body had heard.

The forest remained unnaturally quiet around them.

Alaric's breathing trembled between him and the creature, his heart striking so violently that it seemed to miss one beat only to hammer twice as hard with the next, while every instinct inside him begged him not to move, not to resist and not to give the thing holding him any reason to tighten its grip.

But the scream still lingered beneath his ribs.

Itha's scream.

Alaric stared into the hollow emptiness only a breath from his face, terrified of the creature before him yet unable to stop the question from forcing its way through the panic.

“How? How is it possible that you have Itha's voice?”

The Nightmare did not react.

Alaric swallowed, his throat tightening as the silence stretched between them.

“What have you done to her?”

Nothing.

No movement came from the hollow face before him, no voice emerged from its mouth and no sign appeared that it even understood the desperation in his words, leaving Alaric trapped beneath its grip with nothing but the memory of Itha's scream and questions the creature refused to answer.

His fear only deepened, tightening around his chest until even the thought of pulling against the creature's hand made his heart strike harder, because every instinct inside him wanted to remain perfectly still and do nothing that might provoke it.

But there was no mistaking it. It was Itha's voice, unmistakably hers, and Alaric knew it with a certainty that only made the creature before him more terrifying.

Whatever that scream had meant, whatever this creature knew and whatever terror it had forced into his chest with Itha's voice, he could not allow any of it to keep him there while she was still in danger.

Alaric's fingers tightened around the staff.

His arm trembled beneath the Nightmare's grip as he tried to pull it back, barely moving against the strength of its fingers before the claws pressed more firmly into his skin and immediately stopped him.

"Please..."

The word escaped him quietly.

For a moment, Alaric could do nothing but stare into the creature's hollow face, searching desperately for anything within it that might respond to him, until the warning he had heard only minutes earlier returned to his thoughts.

"You said the maggots are coming."

The Nightmare shuddered.

Alaric stopped.

It had been small, little more than a violent tremor passing through its frame, but for the first time since it had seized him, the creature had reacted to something he had said.

Then he noticed its eyes.

The red embers burning deep within those hollow sockets had begun to tremble, their glow shifting unsteadily inside the darkness as another faint shiver passed through the creature.

Alaric stared at them.

Fear.

Until now, he had seen no sign of it in the creature, yet there was no mistaking the way its body trembled at the mention of the maggots.

The Nightmare was afraid.

Alaric's heart continued hammering against his ribs, but he held onto that realization and forced himself to speak again.

“You told me they were coming,” he said, struggling to keep his voice steady. “You said you needed my help, that I had to hurry. You sounded terrified, and when you pointed me home, I followed because I thought something terrible might have happened to Itha!”

Another tremor passed through the Nightmare, the red embers within its eyes shaking more violently, and Alaric felt a flicker of hope beneath his fear. It understood him, and whatever those maggots were, his words seemed to be reaching it.

“Then please... let me go,” he pleaded, his voice beginning to break. “I know you're frightened, but I can't help either of you while you're holding me here. If Itha's in danger, I have to get to her. Let me save her, and I promise I'll save you from the maggots too.”

The creature remained silent until, without warning, the red embers within its eyes flickered and vanished, and the fingers holding Alaric slowly loosened their grip.

Alaric froze.

His arm slipped free, but he did not immediately pull away, and for one strange moment they simply remained there facing one another, Alaric staring into the empty darkness of the Nightmare's hollow eye sockets while the creature stood before him without making a sound.

Then the trembling stopped.

Its shoulders dropped.

Its spine gave beneath it.

The Nightmare pitched forward.

Alaric stumbled backward as the creature struck the snow face-first, its limbs collapsing around it while the black bandages spilling from the open void through its front settled across the frozen ground.

It did not move again.

Alaric planted the staff hard into the snow before his legs could collapse beneath him, his freed arm pulling instinctively against his side while one ragged breath tore into his lungs, followed by another that came no easier.

The pain in his chest remained, no longer feeling as though the scream were actively trying to tear its way out of him but lingering heavily beneath his ribs, tightening around every deeper breath while the memory of Itha's shriek refused to leave completely.

For several moments, Alaric could do nothing but stand there and breathe, his body trembling around every inhale while the shallow wounds in his right arm slowly began to sting beneath the cold.

Eventually he lowered his gaze.

The Nightmare remained where it had fallen, motionless in the snow, with no twitch of its fingers, no turn of its head and no broken weeping escaping its mouth.

Alaric did not understand why it had fallen.

Before he could search for an answer, another Nightmare began to weep somewhere between the trees, followed by a second farther away and then another, until the brief silence disappeared beneath voice after voice and the forest returned to the same endless mourning as though the creature lying at his feet had never broken from their ranks at all.

There was no time to understand.

Alaric pulled his injured arm closer to his side, tightened his left hand around the staff and turned back toward the path, forcing himself onward despite the pain that immediately caught across his lower back, his first few steps uneven as his exhausted body struggled to follow the urgency driving him home.

Around him, the Nightmares watched from between the trees, their heads turning after him one by one while their long arms remained raised toward the same place ahead, but whatever strange certainty he had begun to find in their behaviour was gone now, shattered by the creature lying motionless behind him and by the voices these hollow things had somehow carried.

Only moments earlier, one of them had spoken to him with the familiar male voice that had once led him to Itha.

Now another had screamed with Itha's.

Alaric could not understand how either was possible, and the thought made every Nightmare around him feel different than it had before, because he could no longer look at those hollow mouths and know what might come from them.

Another warning.

Another scream.

Another voice he knew.

Or something worse.

Every black figure between the trees had become something unpredictable, every small twitch of a bandage or slight movement of a ruined head enough to tighten his grip around the staff, yet Alaric refused to let his attention linger on any one of them for long, because whatever answers hid behind those creatures could wait until Itha was safe.

None of them moved toward him.

They only watched him pass.

Alaric continued through their midst, his steps slower beneath the exhaustion and his lower back burning with every movement, but the pain no longer stopped him and the fear surrounding him was no longer enough to change the direction in which he walked.

The ground continued rising beneath his boots.

The trees began to thin.

Alaric's heart struck harder.

He knew this place.

The ground continued rising beneath his boots and the trees gradually began to thin as the path drew alongside the small riverbank, until Alaric recognized the slight curve ahead and the narrow opening beyond it, knowing that once he passed between the next stretch of pines the forest should finally open enough for the hut to appear between the trees.

Home was there.

Itha was there.

The thought drove Alaric onward as he pushed harder against the staff and forced himself around the curve, taking one painful step after another until the trees finally opened enough for him to see the place where the hut should have been.

He lifted his head.

And stopped.

For several heartbeats, Alaric could not understand what he was looking at.

The familiar shape of the hut was gone, its roof, walls and the small clearing around it swallowed beneath a darkness so dense that at first his mind tried to make sense of it as shadow gathering between the trees.

Then the darkness moved.

Black bandages drifted through the winter air, and shapes slowly separated from one another until the truth became impossible to deny.

Nightmares.

Hundreds stood between him and the hut, with hundreds more gathered behind them until their numbers stretched farther through the forest than his eyes could follow.

There had to be thousands.

They stood packed between the trees like a living wall, hollow forms gathered so thickly around his home that not a single part of the hut remained visible beyond them.

Alaric's body went cold.

For one terrible moment, the sight of them rooted him in place, his heart hammering against his ribs as the memory of Itha's scream returned with terrible clarity, while every instinct inside him begged him to turn around and flee.

Then the warning returned to him.

The maggots are coming.

The male voice had told him to hurry.

It had pointed him home.

Whatever waited ahead, whatever those creatures feared and whatever Itha's scream had meant, all of it led to the same place.

To her. To home.

Alaric tightened his grip around the staff.

Every Nightmare turned toward him at once.

Thousands of heads twisted in the same motion, and the forest erupted beneath the dry, violent cracking of countless necks shifting together, bone grinding against bone with a sound so impossibly loud and wrong that no human being should ever have been forced to hear it.

Then it stopped.

The cracking vanished.

The weeping vanished with it.

For the first time since Alaric had entered the forest, every Nightmare had fallen completely silent, leaving behind an unnatural stillness so deep that even the faint movement of the winter air between the trees seemed too loud.

Countless red embers burned from the hollow sockets ahead, all of them fixed upon him.

Fear tightened through every part of Alaric's body, but he planted the staff farther into the snow and stepped forward anyway.

Itha was somewhere beyond them.

The woman who had trusted him, the woman he had promised to protect and the woman who had claimed his heart so completely that even thousands of Nightmares could not make him abandon her now.

“I’m coming, Itha,” he whispered.

Without the weeping, his voice seemed to carry farther into the terrible silence than he wanted it to.

Alaric took another step toward the wall of darkness.

Whatever the male voice had tried to warn him about, whatever waited among those creatures and whatever terror still remained inside his chest, none of it would stop him from reaching her.

“Nothing will stop me.”

Another step.

“I will save you.”

And with those words, Alaric entered the darkness to save the one who had claimed his heart.

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Meanwhile farther north, along one of the narrower winter roads leading toward Kalluth, a lone carrier continued through the fading remains of the day, its dark wooden frame moving steadily across a landscape already surrendering to night while the last traces of sunset disappeared behind the distant hills and left only a thin line of dying orange against the pale horizon.

The wheels struck the frozen ground with a heavy, uneven rhythm, breaking through brittle sheets of ice before sinking into the hardened snow beneath, each turn sending a low groan through the axles while iron fittings rattled against wood and the entire carrier shifted whenever it found another rut hidden beneath the white.

Two horses pulled at the front with their heads lowered against the cold, clouds of breath rolling steadily from their nostrils while frost gathered along the edges of their harnesses and their hooves struck hard against the road, carrying the weight behind them farther into the approaching night.

Nathanos sat above the front wheels with the reins held firmly between his hands, his posture straight despite the exhaustion that had settled deeper into him with every passing hour.

A small travelling lamp hung from an iron hook beside him, swaying gently with the movement of the carrier, its wick having been lit only a short while earlier by the smallest touch of his inner flame, and now its warm golden glow passed again and again across the horses, the frozen road immediately before them, and the banks of snow nearest to the wheels before disappearing into the darkness beyond.

It would not show him everything once night fully reached them, but the road ahead was still long, and even the little light it offered was better than allowing the horses to follow a path neither he nor they could properly see.

Nathanos kept his attention upon the road while allowing his gaze to move whenever the trees drew closer or the path bent around another rise, searching the spaces beneath snow-heavy branches and watching the distant hills whenever they became visible between them, unwilling to trust any part of the land simply because nothing had moved there yet.

The Night Stalker was dead, and Nathanos had been the one to kill her, driving his blade through her chest and into Raphael, who held her firmly from behind. Yet when the mask fell and revealed a face so disturbingly alike his own, the shock of what he had seen, combined with the sight of his fallen squad scattered across the bloodstained clearing, had left him motionless for a moment, unable to comprehend the horror of what had just unfolded.

There had been no time to understand it, nor any room left in his mind to question what he had seen once Raphael's condition demanded everything else from him, and whatever that face meant remained buried beneath the urgency that followed.

Killing her had not made the road safe.

Nightmares still wandered somewhere beyond the forests and mountains of Velldengar, rarely seen until they had already drawn too close, while farther north the war between Kalluth and the Bloodmoon Tribes continued to tear at the land, their warriors having not yet pushed this deeply into the south in any meaningful number, though Nathanos knew better than to believe that armies were the only things capable of crossing whatever boundaries commanders placed upon maps.

Scouts travelled farther than armies did, hunters wandered, raiding parties became separated from larger forces, and men desperate enough to survive a war rarely cared where the borders of another kingdom within Velldengar began, which was reason enough for Nathanos to keep watching every distant rise, every opening between the trees and every dark shape that remained visible for longer than it should while the carrier pressed steadily north-west.

The road he had chosen after leaving the clearing carried them more directly toward Kalluth, cutting across the countryside rather than following the larger routes farther south, and although it was rougher beneath the wheels and considerably less travelled during Deep Winter, Nathanos had known from the beginning that it would bring them home faster.

Hillbranton lay farther back to the south-west by then, and reaching the great crossroads would have required him to turn away from Kalluth and surrender much of the distance they had already gained before eventually having to travel north again, a detour that under ordinary circumstances might have been worth the safety it offered.

Hillbranton was large, busy and accustomed to travellers arriving from every direction, with guards, shelter and enough people that finding someone willing to offer assistance would hardly have been difficult.

But Nathanos could not afford to spend those hours travelling away from the one person he believed might understand what had happened to Raphael.

Ever since leaving that cursed place, the wound had troubled him in a way he could not properly explain, because his inner flame had stopped Raphael from bleeding when nothing else could have, yet it had not healed the flesh in the way Nathanos knew the Holy Flame was capable of doing. The injury remained beneath the bandages, closed but damaged, surrounded by skin marked by heat and by everything Nathanos had been forced to do simply to keep Raphael alive long enough to reach the carrier.

He did not know whether the wound would withstand several more hours of travel, nor could he be certain that the bleeding would not begin again, but turning toward Hillbranton would bring him no closer to understanding what his flame had done.

High Exarch Alexandre might.

He had been the only man capable of wielding the Holy Flame before Nathanos discovered that the same fire rested within him, and it was through Alexandre that he had learned to control it. Nathanos had witnessed him use its sacred warmth to bless others, granting them strength and restoring their health in ways Nathanos had never fully understood, while his knowledge of Nathanos's inner flame had come through years of examinations that had begun in childhood, many of them painful enough that even now, the memory of those familiar hands sent a faint shiver down his spine.

A cold gust of wind swept across the driver's bench, and Nathanos pulled the blanket tighter around his shoulders, his fingers briefly loosening around the reins before settling against the worn leather once more. As he adjusted his grip, his gaze fell upon his right hand, the same hand through which he had guided the Holy Flame into Raphael's wound, and the memory of what had happened inside the carrier returned to him, bringing with it the uneasy thought that his own attempt to save Raphael might have caused him even greater harm.

"Why did it become worse?" he murmured, studying his palm for a moment before looking back toward the road. "It should have healed. I focused the flame as I always would, just as Alexandre taught me, and I felt it answer. I felt the bleeding stop."

He remembered how the golden warmth had gathered beneath his palm and passed into Raphael's body, how carefully he had tried to control it even while the blood continued to escape between his fingers, and how certain he had been that the flame was doing precisely what he intended.

"But why did the cloth and armor become fused to his flesh? I was directing the flame into the wound, not the metal surrounding it." His brow tightened as he remembered the fragments of armor he had been forced to pull from Raphael's body with his bare fingers, the scorched cloth caught beneath his skin, and the terrible pain he had caused while trying to remove them. "How could the heat have spread like that? What did I do wrong?"

He had never attempted to mend an injury so severe, and although he had followed the same principles Alexandre had taught him through years of practice, he could no longer be certain that what he had done was enough, or even that it had worked in the way he believed.

The flame had stopped the bleeding, but Raphael had only grown weaker afterward, and perhaps the injury had simply been too severe for it to repair, or perhaps Nathanos had misunderstood something in his desperation, forcing the flesh closed before the healing could properly reach what lay beneath.

He could not know.

The thought troubled him more than he wanted to admit, particularly when he remembered how Raphael had endured everything that followed without once blaming him for what had happened.

Nathanos tightened his grip around the reins and returned his attention to the road, but another sharp gust of wind caught beneath his blanket, sending a chill through his body despite the fabric wrapped around his shoulders.

His thoughts turned toward Raphael.

If the cold was becoming this difficult to bear outside, he could only hope that the four candles burning within the carrier were still providing enough warmth to protect the man resting behind him.

Nathanos slowly turned his head toward the small window set into the front of the carrier, hoping to catch a glimpse of Raphael through the glass, but frost had gathered across its surface once more, spreading from the corners until only a narrow, blurred patch of candlelight remained visible through the ice.

Nathanos frowned.

The faint candlelight reassured him that the candles were still burning, but with the temperature continuing to fall and the wind finding its way through every narrow opening in the wooden frame, he could no longer be certain that their little warmth was enough to protect Raphael from the cold settling inside the carrier.

He looked toward the road ahead, searching for a place where the horses could safely stand without blocking their path, and after finding a slightly wider stretch between two banks of snow, he gently drew back the reins and brought the carrier to a halt.

The horses slowed with a few uneven steps, their hooves scraping against the frozen ground before they settled, while the wheels gave one final groan beneath the weight of the carrier and the familiar rattling of iron against wood slowly faded into the winter silence.

"Easy," Nathanos murmured, keeping the reins steady until both animals had stopped moving.

He remained on the bench for a moment, his eyes travelling across the surrounding trees and the darkening road behind them, listening for anything that might have followed the carrier or been disturbed by its arrival, but beyond the quiet movement of the horses and the wind passing through the branches, he heard nothing that gave him reason to remain outside.

Nathanos secured the reins, took the travelling lamp from its hook and climbed down, his boots sinking into the hardened snow as he moved toward the carrier door.

The small step creaked beneath his weight when he climbed inside, and as he pulled the door shut behind him, he immediately noticed how cold the air had become, his breath forming a faint mist before him while the wind continued to press against the wooden frame.

All four candles were still burning.

Their flames trembled gently within the holders fixed to the ceiling, their light mingling with the glow of the travelling lamp in Nathanos's hand and falling across the polished wood and the two cushioned benches, though the little warmth they produced had done almost nothing to keep the winter cold from settling inside.

Nathanos's eyes moved immediately toward Raphael.

He lay where Nathanos had left him, resting against the cushioned side of the carrier with his head tilted slightly toward the window, his pale face illuminated by the candles and the lamp Nathanos carried while the blanket that had been wrapped around him earlier had slipped down from one shoulder, leaving part of his clean shirt exposed to the cold.

Nathanos approached him quietly.

"Raphael?"

There was no answer, though he had not expected one.

It was not the first time Nathanos had stopped to check on him since leaving that cursed place, and although he continued to call his name whenever he returned to the carrier, hoping that perhaps the next time would finally bring some reaction, Raphael had remained unresponsive throughout the journey.

Nathanos placed the lamp upon the opposite bench and lowered himself beside Raphael, carefully pulling the blanket back over his exposed shoulder before resting two fingers against his neck, where he found the same weak but steady pulse that had reassured him during his earlier checks.

Yet the coldness of Raphael's skin beneath his fingertips immediately caught his attention.

His brow tightened as he moved his hand toward Raphael's cheek, gently resting his palm against it before brushing a few loose strands of hair away from his forehead and checking there as well, only to find that his skin had grown considerably colder than he remembered from the last time he had stopped.

Nathanos allowed his hand to linger against Raphael's face, watching the faint rise and fall of his chest while the cold beneath his palm confirmed what he had already begun to fear.

"You are freezing," he murmured.

His gaze shifted toward the frosted window, then toward the four candles burning above them.

The coldness of Raphael's skin had confirmed his worries, and with several more hours of road still ahead, Nathanos knew that another blanket would not be enough.

He needed to bring warmth back into the carrier.

His gaze lowered toward his right hand.

He could use his flame.

The thought brought a brief hesitation, his eyes lingering upon the same fingers that had caused Raphael so much pain earlier, and for a moment he remembered the terrible screams that had filled the carrier when he removed the armor, the blood upon his hands and the pieces of cloth and metal he had been forced to pull from the wound.

He had been trying to save him then, just as he was now, but the memory made him reluctant to call upon the same fire again, even for something as simple as warmth.

Yet Raphael was growing cold, and Nathanos could not allow him to lose what little strength remained simply because he feared making another mistake.

This time he would not touch the wound.

He would use the flame only to warm himself, allowing Raphael to draw heat from their closeness without directing the fire into his body, and although exhaustion had settled heavily into his limbs, Nathanos knew he still had enough strength left to manage that much.

Moving carefully, Nathanos reached toward the opposite bench and took one of the remaining blankets, placing it beside him before lifting the edge of Raphael's blanket and slipping beneath

it himself. He then shifted closer along the bench until their bodies rested together, with as little space between them as possible.

He then eased one arm behind Raphael's shoulders and gently drew him against his chest, supporting the back of his head with his other hand while making certain that the movement placed no unnecessary pressure upon the wound beneath his bandages.

Raphael's unconscious body settled heavily against him as his head came to rest just below Nathanos's shoulder, and Nathanos adjusted his hold until he was certain that neither his neck nor his injured abdomen would be strained by the position. Once Raphael's head rested securely against his chest, he drew the blanket around them both and settled his other arm across Raphael's upper back, holding him close enough that he would not slip from his embrace.

"There," he whispered, lowering his head slightly. "I've got you."

For a moment, Nathanos remained still, allowing Raphael's weight to settle against him while he listened to the faint movement of his breathing, his cheek resting lightly against the pale hair beneath his chin.

With Raphael held so closely, Nathanos could feel the faint rhythm of Raphael's heartbeat against his own chest, each beat weak but present, giving him something reassuring to concentrate upon as he prepared to call upon his flame.

He closed his eyes.

Slowly, he allowed his inner flame to answer.

A gentle warmth gathered deep within him, spreading through his chest and shoulders before reaching the rest of his body, and Nathanos carefully increased it until his own skin began to grow warm beneath his clothes, allowing Raphael to draw heat from their closeness without directing the flame into him.

As the warmth spread, a faint golden glow began to emerge from Nathanos's body, illuminating the space beneath their shared blanket before slowly growing bright enough to reach the surrounding walls. It was not much stronger than the light of the four candles burning above them or the travelling lamp resting on the opposite bench, but together they filled the carrier with a warmer, steadier light, softening the shadows that had gathered along the polished wood and the corners of the cushioned benches.

Nathanos felt the familiar strain almost immediately, his exhausted body having little strength left to offer, but he kept the warmth steady, holding Raphael securely against his chest as the cold trapped between them gradually began to retreat.

"Just a little longer, Raphael," he murmured, his hand moving gently against Raphael's upper back while he kept his head supported against his chest. "We still have some road ahead of us, but once we reach Kalluth, I will take you straight to Alexandre. He understands the flame better than anyone, and if something went wrong when I tried to heal you, he will know what to do."

Nathanos swallowed, his eyes remaining closed as he concentrated upon maintaining the warmth within his body, carefully increasing it until the air beneath the blanket had begun to grow comfortable and Raphael's skin no longer felt quite so cold against his own.

"You just need to hold on until then. You have already done more than enough, and I will take care of the rest."

He lowered his head slightly, resting his cheek against Raphael's hair while the gentle heat continued to spread through him, and for a while he said nothing, allowing himself to remain close to the man he had spent so many hours trying to keep alive.

The golden glow around Nathanos slowly grew brighter, reaching beyond the blankets and spreading across the carrier as the warmth of his body began to heat the surrounding air. Frost softened along the nearest window, and thin trails of moisture ran down the glass while the four candles continued to burn above them and the travelling lamp remained lit on the opposite bench, their light mingling with the golden radiance spreading from Nathanos's body.

He kept Raphael close throughout, careful not to let his head shift or his body slide from the position in which he rested, though maintaining the flame was becoming increasingly difficult as the effort began to draw upon what little strength remained in him.

A thin layer of sweat formed along Nathanos's forehead and beneath the pale strands of hair resting against his temples, and as he continued to hold the warmth steady, his breathing grew heavier, each breath becoming more deliberate than the last.

He could feel his own heart beating harder beneath his chest, the rhythm gradually quickening as the flame continued to draw upon his exhausted body, but he refused to stop while Raphael's skin still felt cold against him.

Nathanos kept his eyes closed, concentrating upon the warmth passing through his body while the man resting against him continued to breathe, and for a while the only sounds within the carrier were the quiet crackling of the candles, the wind pressing against the wooden walls and the increasingly uneven rhythm of Nathanos's own breathing.

Only when he could finally feel warmth returning to Raphael's cheek and neck did he begin to withdraw the flame.

The golden light surrounding him slowly faded, retreating from the walls and the cushioned benches until only the four candles and the travelling lamp remained to illuminate the carrier, while the heat he had gathered continued to linger beneath their shared blanket and in the air around them.

Nathanos opened his eyes.

For a moment, he remained exactly where he was, holding Raphael against him while he tried to steady his breathing, but as the last of the glow disappeared, the full weight of his exhaustion seemed to settle upon him at once.

His heart was racing.

Each beat struck hard beneath his chest, faster than it should, and when he drew in another breath, it came shorter than he expected, forcing him to pause before attempting another.

Nathanos swallowed and lowered his gaze toward Raphael, who remained unconscious against him, his face resting beneath Nathanos's shoulder while the warmth of his body was now considerably more reassuring than it had been when Nathanos first entered the carrier.

"That should be enough for now," he whispered.

He remained there a little longer, allowing his breathing to settle before carefully loosening his hold, sliding one arm beneath Raphael's shoulders to support his upper body while he eased him away from his chest. Raphael's head rested heavily against his hand, and Nathanos moved slowly, lowering him back toward the cushioned side of the bench without allowing his neck to fall or his injured abdomen to twist beneath the blanket.

Once Raphael was settled, Nathanos adjusted the pillow behind his head and gently withdrew his arm, making certain that he remained comfortably supported before turning his attention toward the blanket they had shared.

He drew it securely around Raphael's body, tucking the fabric along his sides and over his shoulders while keeping it loose around the bandaged wound, then reached for the additional blanket he had placed beside him and carefully spread it over Raphael, adding a second layer to preserve the warmth he had worked so hard to restore.

Nathanos paused with his hands resting against the fabric, studying Raphael's face before gently placing his palm against his cheek once more.

Warm.

Not as warm as Nathanos would have liked, perhaps, but no longer carrying the terrible cold he had felt earlier.

He allowed himself a small breath of relief, his hand remaining against Raphael's face for a moment longer while he watched the faint movement of his chest beneath the blankets.

"I promise I will get you home," he whispered. "Whatever it takes, Raphael."

The words remained between them, unanswered, and for a little while Nathanos stayed beside him, reluctant to leave now that he had finally managed to bring some warmth back into his body.

But the road would not grow shorter while he remained there.

Nathanos slowly withdrew his hand and forced himself to stand, steadying his weight against the edge of the opposite bench when an unpleasant heaviness passed through his limbs.

The movement brought another sudden pounding beneath his chest, accompanied by a brief tightness that made him pause before drawing a deeper breath, and Nathanos placed one hand over his heart as he waited for the sensation to pass.

Sweat still clung to his forehead, but as the warmth of his inner flame faded, Nathanos became aware of a chill spreading through his own body. It felt strange after the heat he had gathered within himself, and although the carrier remained considerably warmer than before, he could feel his skin growing cold beneath his clothes, as though the effort of maintaining the flame had taken more from him than he had realized.

He closed his eyes briefly, keeping his hand against his chest while he tried to steady his breathing, but the pounding of his heart continued for several moments before gradually beginning to settle. He folded his arms closer against his body, troubled by the cold creeping

through him despite the warmth of the carrier, and waited until he felt steady enough to move again.

Then he looked toward Raphael.

He lay beneath the two blankets, his pale face illuminated by the candles and the travelling lamp while his breathing continued in the same shallow rhythm Nathanos had watched throughout the journey, and for a moment Nathanos simply stood there, allowing himself the small reassurance of seeing him resting more comfortably than before.

"Rest well, my dear friend," he murmured.

Then he turned toward the door and reached for the travelling lamp he had placed upon the opposite bench when he entered, taking it carefully by its handle before making his way toward the small step.

The door opened with a low groan, allowing the cold night air to rush inside. Nathanos felt it immediately, the chill passing through his clothes and settling against skin that had already begun to grow cold, but he stepped out into the snow and carefully pulled the door shut behind him, making certain not to let it strike the frame too hard.

He stood for a moment beside the carrier with the lamp in his hand, its golden light falling across the snow around his boots while the wind swept past him, making the warmth he had left inside feel all the more distant.

Then he heard something.

A faint sound carried through the darkness somewhere to his side, so quiet that Nathanos might have mistaken it for the wind passing between the trees had it not come again, a soft, broken sniff followed by what sounded unmistakably like someone weeping.

Nathanos lifted his head, his fingers tightening around the handle of the lamp as he searched the snow-covered roadside. The horses shifted uneasily behind him, their harnesses giving a faint rattle, but his attention had already settled upon something farther ahead, standing motionless on the road toward Kalluth.

A shadow.

Its outline was almost lost against the trees, well beyond the reach of his lamp, but as Nathanos narrowed his eyes, two faint points of red emerged from within the darkness.

His body tensed.

A Nightmare.

His already racing heart struck harder against his chest as he shifted his footing, keeping the carrier behind him while his free hand moved instinctively toward the hilt of his sword.

The weeping continued, soft and strangely human, and although he could make out little beyond the creature's silhouette, the red embers remained fixed upon him.

Nathanos could not afford another fight, not when the effort of warming Raphael had left him exhausted and struggling to catch his breath, yet whatever the creature intended, he would not allow it to come any closer to the carrier.

Keeping his fingers firmly around the hilt, he raised the travelling lamp and began moving cautiously along the frozen road, each step bringing its golden light a little farther into the darkness.

Another sob reached him.

Nathanos stopped, his hand tightening around the sword as he watched the creature for the slightest movement.

Then came a sound he had not expected.

A dry, splintering crack broke through the weeping, followed by another, as though bones were slowly being forced out of place somewhere within the dark silhouette.

Nathanos froze, his eyes fixed upon the two red embers.

And from the darkness, a broken male voice emerged.

"The maggots are coming."